Inheritance also obliges the ghatwars to dock their boats only at specific ghats. Santosh explains that the prevalent code of conduct requires each Mallah to pick up passengers only from the boat's native ghat. If he drops passengers off at another ghat, he must return empty to his own ghat to solicit new customers. A ghatwar's income therefore depends heavily on his native ghat. The four most popular of the eighty ghats generate far higher earnings. According to Santosh, a few hundred ghatwars own about 2000 boats across the eighty ghats, operated by over 6000 Mallah men.[39]

Why do other Mallahs put up with the unfair hereditary arrangement? Santosh, a ghatwar himself, acknowledges the unfairness. But he only supports reforming the system, not dismantling it. He favours limiting the number of boats a ghatwar can own, so more Mallah men can enjoy the hereditary right to own a boat. Outsiders might see a paradox here: the Mallahs monopolize a profession in the name of caste rights *and* chafe at the caste system for giving them a lowly status. They want the state to continue their unfair exclusive right to a caste profession *and* provide them the fairness of caste-based reservations to combat persisting social inequities. Such apparent paradoxes derive from the harsh reality and inner logic of the caste system itself, and no section of its hierarchy—especially its upper rungs—is free of them.